

Birthright or house Boon; this increases a character's maximum rating accordingly. For instance, the satyr Birthright of Physical Prowess bestows a free dot of Stamina, so satyr characters have a maximum of 6 for that Trait.

Step Six (Optional): Merits and Flaws

During the freebie points stage, you also may have the option of selecting special Traits called Merits and Flaws. As the name implies, Merits provide benefits to your character, while Flaws impose certain penalties or difficulties. While useful tools for customizing characters, these are also optional Traits, and the Storyteller may choose to restrict or disallow some or all Merits or Flaws as part of his chronicle. Make sure to consult with the Storyteller before selecting them.

Merits have a listed cost in freebie points, with the more powerful or universally applicable Merits having higher costs. Provided you justify it in your character's backstory and can pay the freebie point cost, there is no limit to how many Merits you may select for your character, so long as you remember to check with the Storyteller for approval before finalizing your choices.

Flaws work a little bit differently. Selecting a Flaw gives you extra freebie points equal to the listed value of the Flaw; unlike Merits, however, you may only take a maximum of seven points' worth of Flaws. Generally speaking, taking more than that results in a character with too many Flaws to be playable, or invites abuse by having so many Flaws that some will not come up in play. Even if the Storyteller allows going over this maximum, in order to keep the game balanced for other players it is still advisable that no more than seven points of Flaws be counted toward receiving extra freebie points.

Step Seven: Specialties

After freebie points are spent, a character's Traits should now be set. At this time, any Attribute or Ability rated 4 or above receives a *specialty*, reflecting an area or aspect of that Trait where a character is especially gifted. Some suggestions for possible specialties are listed in the relevant Trait descriptions, though players are encouraged to come up with their own specialties as well, subject to Storyteller approval. In addition, certain Abilities, such as Crafts and Performance, require a character to declare a specialty even if they are not rated four dots or higher, reflecting a character's particular area of expertise in such a broad field.

Step Eight: Threshold & Antithesis

While all changelings can gain Glamour from a variety of sources, most find one form or style that calls to them more than others. This is called a *Threshold*, with more benevolent forms known as *Musing* and harsher forms known as *Ravaging*. Though it is true that in general Seelie fae tend to have Musing Thresholds while Unseelie favor Ravaging Thresholds, this does not mean your character must follow those trends. You also do

not have to decide on one now, but may choose a Threshold during play if you prefer. Lists and descriptions of Thresholds can be found on p. 261.

In addition, every changeling has an action that she views as the epitome of Banality, something so soul-crushing and stifling that it curdles her faerie soul. This action is her *antithesis*, and while other changelings might find it only distasteful, to the character it is a Banality trigger. Work with the Storyteller to come up with an antithesis for your character.

Step Nine: Spark of Life

Once all the points are spent and Traits decided, the character creation process returns to a more narrative, descriptive stage designed to take all those numerical values and translate them back into a living, breathing character. There are no set rules or requirements for this process, but it is highly recommended nonetheless, as it will provide a lot of the fine details that make your character a real role to be played instead of just numbers on a character sheet.

Motivation

Figuring out what drives a character involves asking some of the simplest-seeming and yet often most complicated questions to answer: Why does your character do the things she does? What motivates her? What keeps her going when things get difficult? How does she feel about what she does on a daily basis — is she inspired and eager, simply slogging through another day, or actively ashamed or disgusted at the role she's forced to play?

Understanding the basic instincts or ideals that keep her going can reveal a lot about who a character is, whether she hides them deep down or wears them proudly on her sleeve. After all, even an apparently aimless hedonist who never settles down, but drifts from town to town seeking only pleasure and excitement still has motivations, if very simple ones; and what's more, understanding what in her life put her on that path can be quite a revealing exploration.

Goals are another aspect of character development worth exploring. In *Changeling*, characters may actually be sworn to complete great quests or could be under a magical compulsion to perform certain deeds, which can certainly be tremendous motivating factors for a character's actions. Not all goals need to be quite so grand, however — a character who simply wants to avoid failing out of school and keep her girlfriend happy while balancing her duties as a courtier in the local noble household is definitely just as motivated in her own way as any hero on some epic journey. It's also not unusual for characters find themselves deciding between goals for the changeling world that conflict with mundane aspirations; in fact, it's part of the essence of the setting.

As a player, you may find it useful to think of a daily goal, a short term goal, and a long term goal for your character. The daily goal expresses a character's day to day motivation, whether it's finding enough food to get by, taking care of his kids, or trying to climb the corporate ladder. The short term goal is something that can be accomplished in a few chapters,